alone or sometimes with partners, like other family members. A contributing family worker typically works on a self-employment basis and not as a partner in an establishment of a family member. Employer-workers are self-employed but also employ one or more paid workers.

In 2019, 53 per cent of workers in the global workforce were wage and salaried workers, 34 per cent own account workers, 11 per cent contributing family members and only about 2 per cent were employers. The proportion of workers in wage and salaried employment in the world has been going up constantly. It rose from 44 per cent in 1990 to 48.5 per cent in 2010 and is near 53 per cent now.

India lags far behind the global average on these indicators. Only about 24 per cent of Indian workers were in wage and salaried jobs in 2020 as against the global average of 53 per cent. The share of workers with wage and salaried jobs, however, is rising at a good clip, having gone up from a measly 14.5 per cent in 1990 to 24 per cent in 2020. There has been an accelerated increase after 2010—it was only 16.7 per cent in 2010; in a decade, it rose to 24 per cent, virtually rising by 0.7 per cent every year.

Average Wage is Low

Official data on the wage profile of India's workers is not available after the 2011–12 National Employment and Unemployment Survey. Average wage in 2011–12 was assessed to be only Rs 247 per day, which was, at the average exchange rate of Rs 53 to a dollar in that year, a little less than $4.7 a day. A large part of India's labour force comprises own account workers and contributing self-employed family members. Their wages are simply not ascertainable. A good part of wage and salaried workers are also casual workers. The average wage of casual workers in 2011–12 was Rs 143 per day, or about $2.7.

In the lockdown imposed after COVID-19, the unemployment ratio fell quickly from about 25 per cent in April to about 7 per cent in September